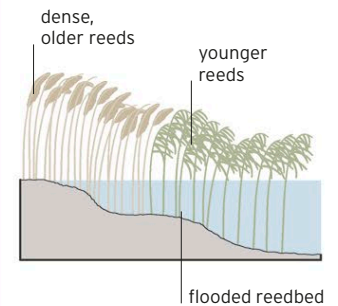




REEDBED STRUCTURE

This cross section of a reedbed shows the succession from young reeds in open water to tightly packed old reeds on higher land. Old reeds give the dense cover needed by nesting birds, while young reeds provide shelter for small fish.



◀ RICH PLANT LIFE

The rich alluvial soils produced by regular flooding in the marshes support a wide variety of plants, including many rare species.

Slovak Karst Caves

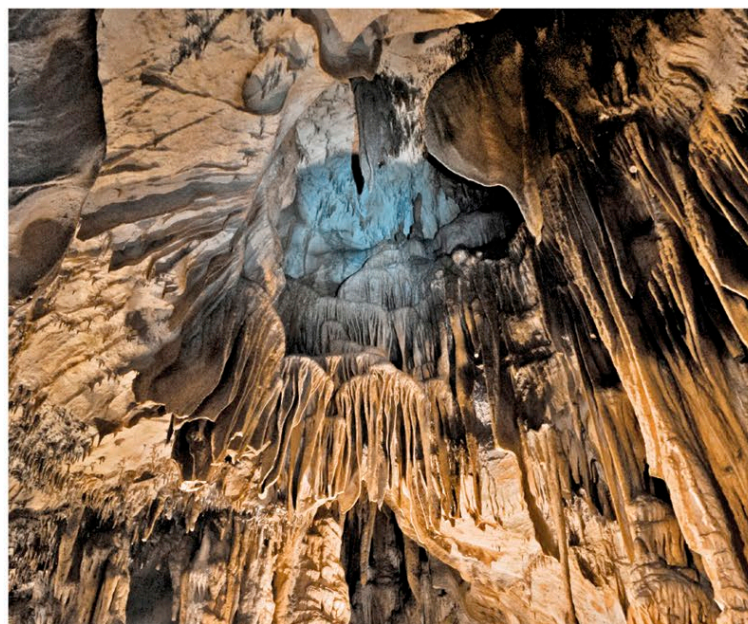
An exceptionally large group of Eastern European caves with a great diversity of formations, a system of major geological and archaeological significance



The Slovak Karst cave system consists of more than 1,000 caves within an area of about 210 square miles (550 square km) along the border between southeastern Slovakia and northeastern Hungary. These diverse and complex caves formed as limestone and dolomite were dissolved by water.

Cave formations

Throughout the system, the caves are richly decorated by an array of structures and formations. The 15-mile- (25-km-) long Baradla-Domica cave complex, one of the most studied, has an elaborate display of stalagmites and stalactites of various shapes and colors, and a stream running through its main section. Like some of the other caves in the region, it shows evidence of ancient human occupation. The Slovak Karst system also includes many ice caves containing year-round ice formations. Perhaps the best known of these, the Dobšinská Ice Cave, was discovered in 1870 and is thought to be about 250,000 years old.



◀ COMPLEX CAVE

The ceiling of the Jasovská Cave is decorated with a variety of stalactites and curtainlike calcite flowstones.